lookahead assertion, which checks the bytes ahead of the current match without moving to them. The syntax for doing so is `(?!...)` and here's what happens when we add it to the example above:

```
preg_match_all('/[a-zA-Z]+c(?!k)/', 'Dock Disc', $matches);
print_r($matches);
```

```
Output:
    [0] => Array
        (
            [0] => Disc
        )
```

This is the correct way to assert that `'c'` is not followed by `'k'`, because it includes the case where nothing at all follows. Additionally, the assertion is zero-width, so there is no inclusion of the sample beyond the previous part of the pattern:

```
preg_match_all('/[a-zA-Z]+c(?!k)/', 'Disc Dock', $matches);
print bin2hex($matches[0][0]);
```

```
Output:
44697363
```

Here are all of the lookaround sub-pattern syntaxes available:

Table 8-33. *PCRE lookaround sub-patterns*

`(?=...)`	Positive lookahead
`(?!...)`	Negative lookahead
`(?<=...)`	Positive lookbehind
`(?<!...)`	Negative lookbehind

Conditional

PCRE, and PHP's implementation of PCRE, allow for an admittedly little-used but quite powerful feature: *conditional* sub-patterns. With this syntax it is possible to specify certain conditions that – if met (or not) – dictate a subsequent match. The test part of the sub-pattern works in one of two ways: either checking if numbered/named/relative